🐾 PAWSITIVELIVING

10 Warning Signs Your Dog Is Sick

What to watch for, what it might mean, and when to call your vet right away.

> Dogs can't tell you when something's wrong — and they're wired to **hide pain and illness** as a survival instinct. By the time most owners notice, the problem has often been going on for a while. This checklist helps you catch things early, when treatment is simpler and less expensive.

🚨 CALL YOUR VET TODAY IF YOU SEE THESE

1 URGENT

Bloated or Distended Belly

Especially in large/deep-chested breeds (Labs, German Shepherds, Great Danes). Can indicate GDV (gastric dilatation-volvulus) — a life-threatening emergency that can kill within hours. Don't wait — go to an emergency vet immediately.

2 URGENT

Sudden Collapse or Extreme Weakness

If your dog suddenly can't stand, is limp, or collapses — this is an emergency. Could be heart failure, internal bleeding, or neurological crisis. Get to a vet immediately.

3 URGENT

Difficulty Breathing or Blue/Grey Gums

Labored breathing, open-mouth breathing (in dogs), or pale/blue/grey gums means your dog isn't getting enough oxygen. Emergency vet right away.

⚠️ SCHEDULE A VET VISIT THIS WEEK

4

Not Eating for More Than 24–48 Hours

Skipping one meal can be normal. Missing 2+ meals, or refusing food they normally love, signals something is off — pain, nausea, dental issues, or illness.

5

Excessive Thirst or Urination

Drinking more water than usual and needing to go outside constantly can signal diabetes, kidney disease, Cushing's disease, or a urinary tract infection. Often missed because owners assume "they're just thirsty."

6

Vomiting or Diarrhea More Than Once or Twice

Occasional stomach upset is normal. But repeated vomiting, blood in vomit/stool, or diarrhea lasting more than 24 hours needs attention. Dehydration can set in fast, especially in small dogs and puppies.

7

Sudden Change in Behavior or Mood

Is your usually playful dog suddenly hiding, growling when touched, or sleeping all day? Behavior changes are often the first sign of pain. Dogs don't tell you they hurt — they just act differently.

👀 WATCH CLOSELY — MAY NEED ATTENTION

8

Scratching, Licking, or Chewing Constantly

Non-stop scratching, licking paws, or chewing at skin usually means allergies (food or environmental), fleas, or a skin infection. Left untreated, it can cause painful hot spots and secondary infections.

9

Limping or Reluctance to Move

Occasional stiffness after a big play day is normal. But consistent limping, trouble getting up, or avoiding stairs can mean joint pain, arthritis, or an injury that needs treatment.

10

Cloudy Eyes, Head Shaking, or Bad Odor

Cloudy eyes = possible cataracts or glaucoma. Constant head shaking + dark discharge = ear infection. Persistent bad breath = dental disease (which affects the heart, kidneys, and liver long-term). None of these resolve on their own.

Keep All This in One Place 🐾

Track your dog's symptoms, vet visits, vaccines, and medications with our free tools — so you're never scrambling when it matters most.

Get Free Dog Health Tools →

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